power of a single state or even in the system as a whole. Only power was re-arranged to counter aggression. States pursued independent policies and was not bound to each other by permanent alliances. Only when one state threatened the independence of another, did a group begin to coalesce to oppose the belligerent power.

There are instances when such balance of power principles became operative in Europe between 1740 and 1763. There were many alliances between France, Prussia, Saxony, Bavaria on the one hand and Austria, England and Hanover on the other in 1740–1743. In 1744–1745, the line-up was like France, Prussia and Bavaria on the one hand, and Austria, England, Hanover and Saxony on the other. In 1756–1763, the line-up was Prussia and Hanover on one side, and Austria, Russia, France and Saxony on the other. These arrangements were not fool proof and did not prevent war, but what mattered was that there was no ideological crusades as seen in the twentieth century. There was no call for “deFredericking” Prussia as the US “de-Nazified” Germany after the Second World War. Further, those wars were mainly fought over Silesia and did not result in large-scale civilian casualties although a large number of soldiers were killed.[3]